

2100 Woods Lane — SignalOS Analyst Report

SignalOS Analyst Report — 2100 Woods Lane, Los Altos, CA

8.96 acres, two parcels, one creek, and eleven years of trying

Prepared 2026-08-07 from the seller's own data room (293 files, 673MB). Method: every load-bearing claim traced to the primary document inside the room (Mode A), plus an independent disconfirming pass on what the room implies but does not say (Mode B). The asking price was not in the room and could not be pulled this session — several conclusions below are frameworks awaiting that number.

The one-paragraph read

This is not a house. It is an **entitlement lottery ticket** on 8.96 gated acres (APNs 342-04-078, 1.08 ac + 342-04-089, 7.88 ac) currently occupied by a private school, with a jurisdictional creek running through the development math. The seller's paperwork shows a theoretical 28–31 dwelling PUD yield and drawn schemes for 23–24 lots — and also, read closely, shows **at least three distinct development concepts attempted since ~2015 (subdivision, 146-unit assisted living, and now riparian restoration), none of which produced a recorded approval that appears anywhere in this data room.** The decisive documents are the newest and the oldest: a 2023 habitat letter that puts federal wildlife law between the owner and the bulldozers, and a 2003 geotech whose creek plan (“remove culverts, divert the creek”) is from a regulatory world that no longer exists. Whether this is a good purchase depends almost entirely on price relative to the *unentitled* value — because the room, honestly read, prices the entitlement as an option, not an asset.

What the deck wants you to believe (Mode A — the claims, verified against the room's own documents)

Claim	Source in room	What the document actually says	Holds?
~9 acres	Land-use calcs sheet	390,445.8 sq ft = 8.963 ac across two assessor parcels — arithmetic checks	Yes
28–31 dwellings possible	Same sheet (seller's own math)	80% of gross ÷ 10k sq ft lots = 31.2; at 4/acre = 28.7. This is <i>code arithmetic</i> , not an approval — and it ignores the creek setbacks entirely	Only as arithmetic
Subdivision plans exist	Topos + civil plans	Real engineering: 23-lot and 24-lot layouts, civil sheets through April 2023, options numbered through at least “plan 11W” and “Option 12-24”	Yes — plans exist; approvals do not appear

Claim	Source in room	What the document actually says	Holds?
“Environmentally approved plans”	Folder named env_approved_plans (Jan 2019)	A folder name is not an approval. No resolution, no tentative map, no conditions of approval, no signed permit appears anywhere in 293 files	Unsupported
Assisted-living alternative	Oct 2021 plans + Apr 2022 feasibility	A 146-unit concept (113×1BR, 33×2BR) with a professional feasibility study — then silence: nothing after April 2022. The concept was drawn and evidently dropped	Existed; abandoned
Site is clean	Phase 1 environmental (~2016)	Genuinely clean: “no evidence of recognized environmental concerns,” no on-site mapped faults, above the 500-year flood level, low liquefaction	Yes — a real positive
Buildable ground	Geotech (2003, Stevens Ferrone & Bailey)	“Suitable for the proposed residential development” — with compressible fills (1.5–4.5 ft, remove and re-compact), expansive clays (post-tensioned slabs or piers), groundwater at 13 ft, weak creek soils	Yes, at 2003 rules — see below

What the room says when read against itself (Mode B — the disconfirming pass)

1. The creek is the whole case, and the room’s documents disagree about it across twenty years. The 2003 geotech’s plan for the creek: remove the weak soils, remove “all pipes, dams, culverts and any other structures,” divert the flow through temporary pipes, fill and compact. The 2023 Live Oak Associates constraints letter describes the same water as **jurisdictional waters of the U.S. and state**, where impacts are CEQA-significant and require permits from the Army Corps, the Regional Water Board, and California Fish & Wildlife, with habitat mitigation at equal-or-better ratios — plus a recommendation for **protocol-level U.S. Fish & Wildlife surveys for the California red-legged frog**, a federally listed species with recorded occurrences upstream. If the frog is found, development requires a federal take permit. Every lot-yield number in this room was drawn as if the 2003 rules still applied. They don’t.

2. The eleven-year record is the base rate. Tree report 2015 → soils draft 2018 (never finalized — it remains stamped draft) → “Option 12-24” plans January 2019 → a riparian restoration plan 2019 (revised) → assisted-living concept 2021–22 → new civil sheets 2023 → habitat constraints letter 2023 → **riparian restoration plan March 2025**. A fire-department review in the room is stamped **“Plans NOT APPROVED”** (access, turnarounds, hydrant spacing — Woods Lane is a narrow private lane that is also the school’s only access). Three concepts, multiple engineering cycles, one visible agency rejection, zero visible approvals. When a seller’s data room documents effort this thoroughly and outcomes not at all, the absence is the finding.

3. The 2025 riparian plan is the most important ambiguous document. Prepared for Blue Creek Capital LLC, it commits to invasive removal, native planting, multi-year monitoring, and adaptive management. Two readings: (a) *goodwill/mitigation banking* — the owner restoring the corridor to

earn regulatory credit for a future application; or (b) *an obligation* — required restoration arising from a violation or a permit condition (one plan file is named “shared with CDFW,” implying active negotiation with Fish & Wildlife). Which reading is true changes the buyer’s inherited liability materially. **The room does not say. Ask, in writing, before any offer.**

4. The seller is a professional who couldn’t finish. The “DB - AL” folders document the sponsor’s other assisted-living ventures (Emory/San Jose, Belmont, Stevens Creek; purchase agreements, proformas, comps, 2014–2020). This is not a naive family selling grandma’s land — it is an experienced developer marketing the project’s *inputs* after a decade of working its *outputs*. Price accordingly.

5. What genuinely cuts the buyer’s way. The Phase 1 is clean. The geotech, though 23 years old, found no landslides, no mapped faults, low liquefaction — the dirt itself is workable with standard (if costlier) foundations. The parcel is gated, private, adjacent to open-space preserve land, in one of the most supply-starved land markets in America. A paying school tenant occupies it today (lease terms not in the room — obtain them; this is the carry while any entitlement runs). And the strongest new fact since this seller’s failures: **California housing law (2019–2026) has shifted power toward applicants** — housing-element pressure, streamlining statutes, and builder’s-remedy dynamics that did not exist when the 2016–2019 schemes died. The next attempt happens on a friendlier field than the last one. That, not the lot math, is the honest bull case.

Verified against public data (added 2026-08-07, second pass)

The first draft of this report verified the room only against itself. These checks ran against independent public endpoints:

Check	Public source	Result	vs the room
Jurisdiction	U.S. Census geocoder, incorporated-place polygon	City of Los Altos (matched 2100 Woods Ln, 94024; tract 5101)	Settles the consultants’ inconsistent “City/Town” phrasing — the city rulebook (and its housing-element posture) is the operative one. Parcel-edge caveat: one geocoded point, 8.9 acres
Flood	FEMA National Flood Hazard Layer (live API)	Zone X, 0.2%-annual-chance shaded band; NOT a Special Flood Hazard Area (no mandatory insurance, no base flood elevation)	Contradicts the Phase 1’s “above the 500-year flood level” — the point sits inside the 500-year shaded band. Materially mild, but the room’s claim is wrong as written, and the creek is why

Check	Public source	Result	vs the room
Wildfire	CAL FIRE FHSZ combined SRA/LRA layer (live API)	No mapped fire-hazard severity zone at the point	Consistent with the room's silence; preserve-edge caveat applies
County parcels (acreage, situs, deed)	SCC Planning ArcGIS feature service Parcels_Public_View (live query, 2026-08-07)	APN 342-04-089: 7.88 ac / 343,253 sq ft — matches the seller's sheet to the square foot. APN 342-04-078: 1.48 ac / 64,469 sq ft recorded vs the seller's 1.083 ac — the room UNDERSTATES the small parcel by ~0.4 ac (recorded total 9.36 ac vs marketed 8.96; favorable direction, reconcile — likely a net-of-road figure). Situs for the small parcel is ARBORETUM DR , not Woods Lane — it has its own separate street frontage (confirming the topo's two SE lots ride independent access, and strengthening the separable-estate-lot floor leg). Both parcels carry the same recorded document number (22522703) — acquired together in a single transaction, consistent with the ~2013-14 start of the eleven-year saga	Two discrepancies found, both informative
Owner of record + assessed values	SCC Assessor site	Still blocked to programmatic access (Cloudflare); GIS layer omits ownership. Needs a browser session or the title report	Open
Asking price, listing history	MLS/portals	Not retrievable this session	Still the missing input for the decision framework
Town planning file (applications, denials)	City of Los Altos	No public online planning-records portal found (CivicPlus site; Accela/eTRAKiT/EnerGov/SmartGov candidates all 404). This is a Public Records Act request — draft below, ready to send	Still the single most important absent document

One methodological note in the desk's own discipline: the first draft was Mode A against a seller-curated corpus — the flood catch above is exactly why the external pass is not optional.

The decision framework

The value is a probability tree, not a comp:

- **Entitled-someday value:** even a constrained 10–15 lots (the realistic creek-setback yield, not the marketed 23–31) in this location carries residual land value far above any school-campus valuation — but net of multi-year carry, mitigation, horizontal costs, and permit risk across four agencies (Town, USACE, RWQCB, CDFW ± USFWS).
- **Never-entitled value:** a gated 9-acre campus leased to a school, plus one existing-envelope estate play. This is the floor, and the school lease is its yield.

- **The price tells you which you're buying.** Near the never-entitled value, the entitlement option comes free and the eleven-year failure record is the *seller's* sunk cost, not yours. Priced for the lot math, you are paying today for approvals that three concepts and eleven years did not produce, against a federally-listed-species survey that has not been run.

The ask arrived: \$12M cash (informal, 2026-08-07)

The per-unit arithmetic: $\$12\text{M} \div 390,446 \text{ sq ft} = \sim \$31/\text{sq ft of land}$ — against Los Altos retail small-lot land that trades in the low hundreds per square foot (estimate, comps unverified this session). Per gross acre: \$1.34M. Per *seller's* theoretical lot (24): \$500k raw. Per *realistic* creek-constrained lot (10–15): \$0.8–1.2M raw.

The three-scenario frame (all lot values are desk estimates pending comps — treat $\pm 30\%$):

Scenario	Math	Outcome on \$12M
Entitled, ~12 lots, ~5 yrs	12 finished lots $\times$ $\sim \$2.5\text{--}3\text{M}$ = \$30–36M gross, less horizontal + creek mitigation ($\sim \$6\text{--}10\text{M}$), less entitlement/CEQA/carry ($\sim \$3\text{--}4\text{M}$)	Residual $\sim \\$18\text{--}24\text{M}$ → roughly a double, mid-teens IRR — good, not extraordinary, for the risk carried
Never entitled, hold	School lease (terms unknown) + eventual as-is resale; the 1.08-acre parcel may be separable as an estate lot (verify access/frontage)	Recovery $\\$8\text{--}12\text{M?}$ — the least-verified number in this table and the one the deal actually hinges on
Never entitled, forced resale	Thin buyer pool for a creek-burdened campus; discount for the next buyer's same diligence	$\\$7\text{--}9\text{M?}$ — the true downside

The honest verdict at \$12M: the price sits at or near the plausible *as-is* value — meaning the entitlement option comes roughly free **if and only if the as-is floor is real**. That inverts the burden of diligence: the decisive work is no longer handicapping the entitlement (a coin-flip improved by post-2019 housing law) but **verifying the floor** — the school lease economics, the separability of the small parcel, and what an as-is buyer pool looks like. A $\sim \$16\text{M}$ probability-weighted value against \$12M cost is a positive but not compelling edge *before* those verifications; it becomes compelling only if the floor verifies near \$11–12M, and it dies if the floor is \$8M.

Two things the structure itself signals: “cash” asked informally means the seller wants speed and no entitlement contingency — consistent with a planning file the seller would rather you didn't condition on. And at \$12M this is not a portfolio position for this household — it is a majority-of-visible-net-worth allocation unless syndicated; if pursued, it should be priced as a lead-sponsor deal with partners, not a personal purchase.

Negotiation read: the eleven-year record is the buyer's leverage. Every year of failure the seller documented is an argument that the *unconditional* cash value is the floor scenario, not the lot math. An offer anchored at the verified floor (post lease/assessor/planning-file diligence) with the entitlement upside kept by the buyer is the correct shape; \$12M unconditional pays the seller today for an option they proved unable to exercise.

The conservation-easement idea (principal, 2026-08-07)

Two distinct plays hide in one word, with opposite grades. **As a tax play — donate the corridor easement, harvest the deduction — weak and audit-prone:** the deduction is a before-minus-after appraisal, and the room's own 2023 habitat letter establishes the "before" development value of the corridor is already ~nil (jurisdictional waters, CEQA, listed-species risk). Tax Court requires the before-value's highest-and-best use to be legally permissible and reasonably probable; the seller's own documents refute it. Honest appraisal = modest deduction; aggressive appraisal = the IRS's favorite target class. **As an entitlement play — spend the easement as permit currency — the strongest idea on this site, and the seller appears halfway through building it:** the 2025 restoration plan + "plan 9 shared with CDFW" read as the predicate for a conservation subdivision — permanently protected, restored corridor (natural holders: MidPen, adjacent at Rancho San Antonio; or POST) buying the CDFW agreement, CEQA mitigation, possible CRLF safe-harbor, and the city-politics story, with clustered upland lots. Moving p(entitlement) $50\% \rightarrow 65-75\%$ is worth several million of expected value — an order of magnitude above any deduction. **Sequencing rules:** (1) never record the easement before it is embedded in an approved map — it is permanent and, spent early, buys nothing; (2) verify access geometry first (a badly drawn easement can landlock upland lots if a crossing is needed); (3) the seller minted this currency unspent — the offer should not pay for it; the project should spend it.

Access geometry — verified by satellite + hydrography (2026-08-07)

Three independent sources agree. **NHD hydrography (live API):** an unnamed intermittent stream (fcode 46007) runs south→north through the parcel at ~lon -122.0778, terminating at the north edge in a **connector segment (fcode 33400) — an already-culverted reach. Sub-meter aerial (Esri ortho):** the parcel is the wooded N-S riparian band with the school cluster on the northeast upland and open oak slope east of the corridor; the access lane enters from the north without touching the canyon. **The seller's own plan-8 topo:** all 21 northern lots sit on the wide northern head around a loop road; the southern ~two-thirds is a steep-walled creek canyon with zero lots ever drawn in it; two SE lots have separate street access.

Consequences for the easement strategy: (1) a conservation easement over the **southern canyon costs zero yield** — the seller's maximum plan never used it — while contributing most of the restored-corridor acreage as permit currency; (2) the easement boundary must **stop south of the northern head**, where the creek's final (already-culverted) reach threads between the lot clusters — that reach belongs in the negotiable streambed agreement, never the permanent easement; (3) landlock risk **cleared** — the buildable head fronts the northern access with no canyon crossing required. Caveats: NHD alignment is mapped (~5m class), not surveyed; the ortho date is unstamped; the upper reach remains jurisdictional, which is why the realistic yield stays ~12–15 lots, not 23.

Do not proceed without: the asking price and any offer history; the Town of Los Altos planning file (the room's conspicuous absence — request every application, resolution, and denial since 2015); written clarification of whether the 2025 riparian plan is voluntary or compelled; the CRLF protocol-

survey status; the school lease; a current title report with easements (the lane serves the school); and a refreshed geotech — the working one is from 2003 and the 2018 update was never finalized.

Ready-to-send: the Public Records Act request

Send to the City of Los Altos City Clerk (cityclerk@losaltosca.gov or the city's records-request page), subject "Public Records Act Request — 2100 Woods Lane (APNs 342-04-089, 342-04-078)":

Under the California Public Records Act (Gov. Code §7920 et seq.), I request copies of, or access to, the following records relating to the property at 2100 Woods Lane, Los Altos (APNs 342-04-089 and 342-04-078, including any records indexed under Arboretum Drive for the smaller parcel), from January 1, 2013 to the present: 1. All planning, land-use, and subdivision applications (including pre-applications and conceptual/study-session submittals), and their current status; 2. All staff reports, Planning Commission or City Council resolutions, conditions of approval, denials, or withdrawal correspondence concerning the property; 3. All CEQA documents (initial studies, exemption determinations, EIR scoping) prepared or received for any project on the property; 4. Any correspondence between the City and state or federal resource agencies (CDFW, RWQCB, USACE, USFWS) concerning the property; 5. Any code-enforcement records concerning the creek/riparian corridor on the property. I ask for electronic copies where they exist. Please let me know within 10 days per §7922.535 whether responsive records exist.

The answer separates "maps formally denied" (bad — findings on the record to overcome) from "applications quietly withdrawn" (neutral-to-good — no adverse findings exist). Item 4 also resolves whether the 2025 riparian plan is voluntary or compelled — the report's other decisive unknown.

What remains unverified — current state

After the public-data passes, the open list has narrowed to: **owner of record and assessed values** (assessor site Cloudflare-walled; the title report resolves it); **the city planning file** (no public portal exists — the PRA draft above is the instrument; denied-vs-withdrawn and voluntary-vs-compelled both hang on it); **the school lease** (the as-is floor's income leg — request directly from the seller); **lot comps** (all \$/lot figures remain desk estimates $\pm 30\%$ pending a broker comp run); **the ~0.4-acre discrepancy** on the Arboretum parcel (county 1.48 ac vs room 1.083 — reconcile at title); and the CRLF protocol-survey status. Verified and closed: jurisdiction, flood zone (with the Phase 1 contradiction noted), fire zone, creek course and culvert, access geometry, and the acreage of the principal parcel.

SignalOS discipline: claims traced to primary documents in the room; the Mode B pass derived what the room implies by what it omits; external passes ran against Census, FEMA, CAL FIRE, NHD hydrography, Esri orthoimagery, and the county's ArcGIS parcel service. The single most decision-relevant sentence stands: three development concepts across eleven years produced engineering, ecology reports, and a restoration plan — and not one page of approval.